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Sell Before you Build

THE DEFINITIVE STRATEGIC PLAYBOOK

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If you're not selling, you don't have a business

(yet)...

Sales Before Product

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Don't make the same mistake

Founders come to us:

Burned out

Out of cash

Unable to Fundraise

There's a better way...

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~~I need to raise before I start~~

~~'I need money for an app'~~

Tech comes **second**

~~If I just had funding I could launch~~

~~customers need this feature~~

First focus on **solving a real problem** for a niche group of customers.

Then boost your delivery using technology.

Tech is the scale, not the whole business.

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why do it?

RESULTS

Craft the **perfect offer** for your clients leading to better results for them and for you

REVENUE

Generate revenue immediately, in a non-scalable way

RESOURCES

Don’t **waste resources** building the wrong thing

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Sell Before You Build
Strategies

FAKE DOOR

Test your offer
(no delivery)

WIZARD

Sell a tech solution
(deliver manually)

FRANKENSTEIN

Sell a tech solution
(stitch together third party tech)

CONCIERGE

Sell a manual solution
(learn what processes to scale with tech)

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FAKE DOOR

Test your offer

(no delivery)

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FAKE DOOR

Test your offer
(no delivery)

Validate demand for a product or feature before investing significant resources in building it.

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FAKE DOOR

Test your offer *(no delivery)*

Create a **simulated interface** or landing page that **appears functional** but **doesn't actually provide the intended functionality.**

Be Transparent

Inform your customer that your product/service is **not yet available** once you have captured their data.

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FAKE DOOR Example

Dropbox

Dropbox wanted to **validate the demand** for a simple file synchronisation service before building the full technology.

They created a short video demonstrating how Dropbox would work and shared it on technology forums like Hacker News.

The video was a simple walkthrough of the product's proposed functionality, using a basic prototype.

THE RESULT

The overwhelming positive response and a **significant number of sign-ups from the video** demonstration helped validate the demand for Dropbox and attracted initial investor interest.

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WIZARD

Sell a tech solution

(manual delivery)

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WIZARD

Sell a tech solution
(manual delivery)

Simulate functionality of a product or service without building the technology.

Instead, manually deliver the solution when clients buy.

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WIZARD

Sell a tech solution *(manual delivery)*

Low-cost Validation:

Gather feedback, and iterate without investing heavily in development.

Efficacy:

Learn how you can best deliver for your clients.

Flexibility:

Easily modify and adapt your approach based on feedback, without constraints of pre-built tech.

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WIZARD Example

Zappos.com

Zappos: The well-known online shoe retailer (acquired by Amazon) initially used the **Wizard of Oz strategy.**

Before establishing a fully stocked e-commerce website, Zappos approached local shoe stores, took pictures of their inventory, posted them online, and checked if people would buy shoes online.

Whenever a shoe was ordered, the founder would buy it from the store and ship it to the customer.

THE RESULT

This initial test **helped prove the concept** that customers were willing to purchase shoes online **without Zappos initially having any inventory** or back-end logistics system.

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FRANKENSTEIN

Sell a tech solution

(third-party tech delivery)

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FRANKENSTEIN

Sell a tech solution

(third-party tech delivery)

Simulate functionality of a product or service by stitching together pre-existing third party technology solutions to deliver the end result.

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FRANKENSTEIN

Sell a tech solution *(third-party tech delivery)*

Low-cost Validation:

Gather feedback, and iterate with low investment.

Viability:

Minimal technical requirements.

Flexibility:

Less flexible than Wizard, but still no requirement to build bespoke technology.

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FRANKENSTEIN Example

Instagram: In its early days, Instagram heavily relied on third-party libraries and tools to handle various aspects of the app.

For image processing, they used open-source software that allowed users to apply different filters to their photos.

THE RESULT

Instagram integrated seamlessly with other social networks like Facebook and Twitter, using the existing APIs provided by these networks.

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CONCIERGE

Sell a manual solution

(learn what processes to scale with tech)

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CONCIERGE

Sell a manual solution

(learn what processes to scale with tech)

A customer-centric approach used to provide personalised, hands-on service to a small group of early customers.

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CONCIERGE

Sell a manual solution *(learn what processes to scale with tech)*

Build Trust & Loyalty:

Leads to stronger relationships with early users as they receive **highly personalised attention.**

Test Concept:

Learn first hand what **users like, dislike, or want improved.** Make adjustments before starting development.

Iterative Development:

Reduce risk of later changes and **avoid expensive pivots.**

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Example

Wealthfront

Wealthfront, the automated investment service, now provides robo-advisory and financial planning services through a technology-driven platform.

But before fully automating its investment services, Wealthfront initially used direct interactions with clients to understand their financial goals, risk tolerance, and investment preferences.

THE RESULT

By **manually managing** client investments and interacting with them directly, Wealthfront was **able to gather detailed feedback** about what clients valued in an investment service, **what features were most important to them,** and **how the service could be improved.**

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NEXT STEPS

WIZARD

FRANKENSTEIN

FAKE DOOR

CONCIERGE

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Next Steps

Analysis First:

You now have four distinct strategies that will help you to **sell before you build.**

Make a Plan:

Decide which strategy would fit best for your **audience**, **business model**, and your **technical capabilities**.

Take Action:

Remember that **'Done is Better than Perfect'.**

Take the first step to sell before you build, today!

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British Summer Time

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